

Palau



The 300-island Palau archipelago (known locally as Belau) lies in the western Pacific Ocean. It achieved independence in 1994, and is gradually reducing its aid dependence.



GEOGRAPHY

Terrain varies from thickly forested mountains to limestone and coral reefs. Babeldaob, the largest island, is volcanic, with many rivers and waterfalls.



CLIMATE

Hot and wet. Little variation in daily and seasonal temperatures. February–April is the dry season.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Native Palauans are a mix of the original Southeast Asian migrants and Pacific settlers. A modern influx from Asia has led to tension. 70% of the population lives on the island-city of Koror, prompting the construction of a new capital on Babeldaob. Native culture is preserved on outer islands despite strong influence from the US and Japan. Modekngei is a blend of Christianity and local beliefs.

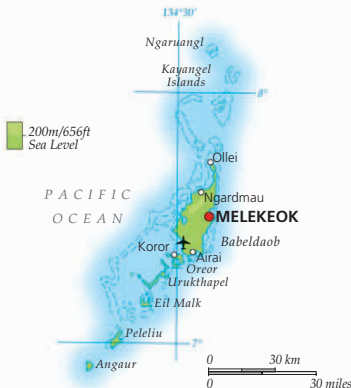


THE ECONOMY

Tourism and fishing licenses are main earners. Coconuts, taro, and bananas. 15-year US aid plan to 2009.



INSIGHT: Palau's reefs contain 1500 species of fish and 700 types of coral



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Palau

DATE OF FORMATION: 1994

CAPITAL: Melekeok

POPULATION: 20,400

TOTAL AREA: 177 sq. miles
(458 sq. km)

DENSITY: 104 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Palauan*, English*, Japanese, Angaur, Tobi, Sonsorolese

RELIGIONS: Christian 66%, Modekngei 34%

ETHNIC MIX: Palauan 74%, Filipino 16%, other 6%, Chinese and other Asian 4%

GOVERNMENT: Nonparty system

CURRENCY: US dollar = 100 cents